

Kristine is Not Well

Seeyam Quine
seeyamq@gmail.com
Independent
USA



Figure 1: *Kristine Is Not Well* banner poster

ABSTRACT

Memes vs. algorithm in metaverse inspired by real rebellion stories. *Kristine is Not Well* is a 20-minute animated VR social media simulation that highlights the resistance of online activists against algorithmic surveillance and censorship.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Social and professional topics** → **Technology and censorship**; • **Computing methodologies** → *Virtual reality*; • **Human-centered computing** → Information visualization.

KEYWORDS

virtual reality, algorithmic censorship, data visualization

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1 INTRODUCTION

Internet activism plays a critical part in modern society, but it often does not get enough attention and is not accurately represented. Digital protests are mostly portrayed in the news in the form of a few isolated screenshots, but cyber activism is incredibly multi-dimensional and involves strong community collaboration. By using VR to transform the 1-dimensional social media facade into an

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Figure 2: Screenshot of sending comments in the VR experience.

embodied experience, we hope to capture the dimensionality of online protests. Wish it could show non-VR artists the possibility of using VR as a medium to better visualize cyber activities.

Kristine is Not Well is an animated social media simulation that visualizes how internet users protest against algorithmic surveillance and censorship with interactive and spatial metaphors in virtual reality (VR). Based on real online protests and existing anti-censorship practices used by online activists, the project uses immersive technology to allow users to more deeply connect and experience the dimensionality of geopolitical social movements.

The story invites the audience to join Owlet, a good-vibes-only social platform that blends elements of TikTok and VRChat, where content creators offer lighthearted experiences like French lessons between reindeer and VR workouts led by a muscular dog. However, when the popular influencer @KristineMusic suddenly gets removed from the platform, the VR experience transforms into a

battle between creativity and automated keyword detection as the user tries to uncover the truth behind Kristine's censorship and bypass the restrictions through the creative use of homophones, emojis, memes, etc.

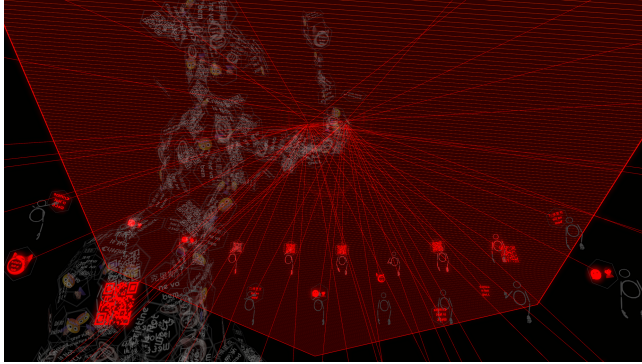


Figure 3: Screenshot of online protests in the VR experience.

2 BASED ON REAL ONLINE PROTESTS

In early 2020, Chinese Internet users reposted COVID news in thousands of different formats to circumvent the information crackdown and inform others about the unfolding epidemic[Hollingsworth and Xiong [n. d.]].

Starting in 2021, QR code has been frequently used to share e-books in America, as their physical copies are being banned from schools[Hernandez 2022].

Since 2022, with the crackdown on protests of the Ukraine war, people in Russia have found ways to express their opposition through homemade figurines[Hernandez 2023].

In the digital age, People's words and online expressions are being harvested for data, and privatized for profit. The unfair use and collection of people's data in the technology industry have been constantly recognized in the past decades but never properly addressed. Although being impacted by algorithms in different means, the ways people around the world fight back are incredibly similar: being more resilient and creative than the algorithm. Yet such resistance is usually under-recognized because of its grassroots nature. In light of increasing data mining everywhere, we want to use *Kristine Is Not Well* to celebrate humanity's resilience and creativity in fighting against the algorithm.

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